



SLOW COOKER & INSTANT POT

# Cozy Crockpot Dinners

5 easy dump-and-go dinners for busy weeks, with 2 cozy recipes from Georgia, where my family lives.



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# How to use this guide



## Slow cooker (Crockpot)

Low and slow. Put everything in before work and come home to dinner. LOW is gentler, HIGH is about twice as fast.



## Instant Pot / pressure cooker

Fast. "Natural release" means you leave the valve closed and let the pressure drop on its own.

## 5 golden rules

**1**

### Fill it halfway to three-quarters.

Too empty and food dries out, too full and it won't cook evenly.

**2**

### Don't lift the lid.

Every peek lets the heat out and can add up to 20-30 minutes to the cooking time.

**3**

### Dairy goes in at the end.

Cream, cheese and milk can split if they cook for hours. Stir them in during the last 15-30 minutes.

**4**

### Tomatoes on top in the Instant Pot.

Thick sauces on the bottom can trigger the burn warning. Layer them on top and don't stir before cooking.

**5**

### Herbs and garlic last.

Fresh herbs and a little raw garlic at the end make every stew taste brighter.

## Good to know

Cooking times are a guide and can vary depending on your appliance and the size of your pieces. Chicken is safe to eat at 74 °C (165 °F). Most dishes keep 3-4 days in the fridge or up to 3 months in the freezer (except the creamy ones).



RECIPE 1 OF 5

# Salsa Pulled Chicken

3 ingredients · tacos, bowls & wraps

Serves 6

Prep 5 min

 Slow cooker LOW 6 h · HIGH 3-4 h

 Instant Pot 12 min + 10 min release

Gluten-free

## Ingredients

- ☐ 900 g (2 lb) chicken breasts or thighs
- ☐ 1 jar salsa (450 g / 16 oz)
- ☐ 1 tbsp taco seasoning
- ☐ Juice of 1 lime
- ☐ Salt to taste



## Slow cooker

LOW 6 h · HIGH 3-4 h

- 1 Put the chicken in the pot and sprinkle with taco seasoning.
- 2 Pour the salsa over the top.
- 3 Cook until the chicken shreds easily.
- 4 Shred with two forks, stir in the lime juice and taste for salt.



## Instant Pot

12 min + 10 min release

- 1 Add ½ cup (120 ml) water to the pot, then the chicken and seasoning.
- 2 Pour the salsa on top. **Don't stir**, so you won't get a burn warning.
- 3 Pressure cook on HIGH for 12 min, then let the pressure release naturally for 10 min.
- 4 Shred, add the lime juice and stir.

## Serve it with

Warm tortillas, rice bowls with corn and avocado, or nachos with melted cheese.

## Leftovers

Keeps 4 days in the fridge. Roll it into a wrap with rice and cheese for tomorrow's lunch.

## MY NOTES



RECIPE 2 OF 5

# Creamy Tuscan Chicken

sun-dried tomatoes · spinach · parmesan

Serves 4

Prep 10 min

 Slow cooker LOW 4–5 h · HIGH 2–3 h

 Instant Pot 10 min + 5 min release

Gluten-free

## Ingredients

- ☐ 700 g (1½ lb) chicken breasts
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) chicken broth
- ☐ 4 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ ½ cup sun-dried tomatoes, chopped
- ☐ 1 tsp Italian seasoning · salt & pepper
- ☐ *To finish:* 1 cup (240 ml) heavy cream
- ☐ ½ cup grated parmesan
- ☐ 2 big handfuls of spinach



## Slow cooker

LOW 4–5 h · HIGH 2–3 h

- 1 Season the chicken and place it in the pot.
- 2 Add the broth, garlic, sun-dried tomatoes and Italian seasoning.
- 3 Cook until tender. Chicken breasts dry out, so don't cook longer!
- 4 Stir in the cream, parmesan and spinach. Cover for 15 min until the spinach wilts.



## Instant Pot

10 min + 5 min release

- 1 Add the broth, then the chicken, garlic, tomatoes and seasoning.
- 2 Pressure cook on HIGH for 10 min, then natural release for 5 min.
- 3 Take out the chicken. Switch to **Sauté**.
- 4 Stir in the cream, parmesan and spinach and simmer 2–3 min. Return the chicken.

## Serve it with

Pasta, rice or mashed potatoes, and crusty bread for the sauce.

## Leftovers

Keeps 3 days in the fridge. Slice the chicken and toss it with pasta and the sauce.

## MY NOTES



RECIPE 3 OF 5

# Chicken Pot Pie Soup

all the comfort, none of the pastry work

Serves 6

Prep 15 min

 Slow cooker LOW 6-7 h • HIGH 3-4 h

 Instant Pot 10 min + 10 min release

## Ingredients

- ☐ 500 g (1 lb) chicken breasts
- ☐ 1 onion, chopped
- ☐ 3 carrots, sliced
- ☐ 2 celery stalks, sliced
- ☐ 2 potatoes, cubed
- ☐ 2 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ 4 cups (1 l) chicken broth
- ☐ 1 tsp dried thyme • salt & pepper
- ☐ *To finish:* 1 cup (240 ml) milk or cream
- ☐ 3 tbsp flour
- ☐ 1 cup frozen peas



## Slow cooker

LOW 6-7 h • HIGH 3-4 h

- 1 Put the chicken, vegetables, garlic, broth and thyme in the pot.
- 2 Cook until the vegetables are soft.
- 3 Take out the chicken, shred it and put it back.
- 4 Whisk the flour into the milk, stir it in with the peas. Cook 20-30 min more on HIGH until thick.



## Instant Pot

10 min + 10 min release

- 1 Add everything except the milk, flour and peas.
- 2 Pressure cook on HIGH for 10 min, then natural release for 10 min.
- 3 Shred the chicken. Switch to **Sauté**.
- 4 Whisk the flour into the milk, stir it in with the peas and simmer 3-5 min until thick.

## Serve it with

Puff pastry squares baked until golden, biscuits or a slice of bread.

## Leftovers

Keeps 4 days in the fridge. It thickens overnight, so add a splash of broth when reheating.

## MY NOTES



RECIPE 4 OF 5

# Ajapsandali

Georgian vegetable stew

Serves 4-6

Prep 20 min

 Slow cooker LOW 6-7 h • HIGH 3-4 h

 Instant Pot 6 min + 10 min release

Vegan

## Ingredients

- ☐ 2 eggplants, cubed
- ☐ 3 potatoes, cubed
- ☐ 2 carrots, sliced
- ☐ 2 bell peppers (red + green), chopped
- ☐ 2 onions, chopped
- ☐ 4 tomatoes, chopped (or 1 can, 400 g)
- ☐ 2 tbsp tomato paste
- ☐ 5 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ 1 small chili (optional)
- ☐ 1 tsp ground coriander · 2 bay leaves · salt
- ☐ 4 tbsp oil
- ☐ *To finish:* fresh cilantro, basil & parsley

## Slow cooker

LOW 6-7 h • HIGH 3-4 h

- 1 Fry the eggplant, onions and peppers in the oil for 5-7 min until golden. This gives the stew its flavor.
- 2 Put them in the pot with the potatoes, carrots, spices and chili.
- 3 Add the tomatoes and tomato paste on top.
- 4 Cook until everything is soft. Stir in the garlic and herbs before serving.

## Instant Pot

6 min + 10 min release

- 1 On **Sauté**, fry the eggplant, onions and peppers in the oil for 5-7 min.
- 2 Add the potatoes, carrots, spices and ½ cup (120 ml) water.
- 3 Add the tomatoes and paste **on top, don't stir**.
- 4 Pressure cook on HIGH for 6 min, natural release 10 min. Stir in the garlic and herbs.

## Serve it with

Fresh bread and a piece of salty cheese. In Georgia it's often eaten warm or at room temperature.

## Leftovers

Tastes even better the next day! Keeps 4 days in the fridge.

## MY NOTES



RECIPE 5 OF 5

# Lobio

Georgian bean stew

Serves 4-6

Prep 10 min

 Slow cooker LOW 6-8 h • HIGH 4 h

 Instant Pot 30 min + 15 min release

Vegan

## Ingredients

- ☐ 400 g (2 cups) dried red kidney beans, soaked overnight
- ☐ 1 onion, finely chopped
- ☐ 4 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ 1 tbsp tomato paste
- ☐ 1 tsp ground coriander
- ☐ ½ tsp blue fenugreek (utskho suneli), optional
- ☐ ½ tsp chili flakes • 1 bay leaf • salt
- ☐ 1 tbsp oil
- ☐ *To finish:* ½ cup crushed walnuts (optional), fresh cilantro

## Slow cooker

LOW 6-8 h • HIGH 4 h

- 1 **Important:** boil the soaked beans hard in a regular pot for 10 min first. Red kidney beans aren't safe if cooked only at low heat.
- 2 Drain and put them in the slow cooker with the onion, spices, tomato paste and oil.
- 3 Cover with water by 3 cm (1 inch) and cook until very soft.
- 4 Mash about a third of the beans. Stir in the garlic, walnuts and cilantro. Season with salt.

## Instant Pot

30 min + 15 min release

- 1 Drain the soaked beans and add them with the onion, spices, tomato paste and oil.
- 2 Cover with water by 3 cm (1 inch).
- 3 Pressure cook on HIGH for 30 min, then natural release for 15 min.
- 4 Mash a third of the beans, then stir in the garlic, walnuts, cilantro and salt.

## Serve it with

Cornbread, pickles and a fresh tomato & cucumber salad.

## Leftovers

Short on time? Use 3 cans of beans (drained): slow cooker 3-4 h on LOW or Instant Pot 5 min.

## MY NOTES

PICK 2 OR 3 FOR THIS WEEK

# Shopping lists

Check the pantry basics first, then add the lists for the recipes you want to cook this week.

## Salsa Pulled Chicken

- ☐ Chicken breasts or thighs · 900 g (2 lb)
- ☐ Salsa · 1 jar (450 g / 16 oz)
- ☐ Taco seasoning
- ☐ Lime · 1

## Creamy Tuscan Chicken

- ☐ Chicken breasts · 700 g (1½ lb)
- ☐ Chicken broth · 1 cup
- ☐ Sun-dried tomatoes · ½ cup
- ☐ Heavy cream · 1 cup
- ☐ Parmesan · ½ cup grated
- ☐ Spinach · 2 handfuls
- ☐ Italian seasoning

## Chicken Pot Pie Soup

- ☐ Chicken breasts · 500 g (1 lb)
- ☐ Carrots · 3 · celery · 2 stalks
- ☐ Potatoes · 2
- ☐ Chicken broth · 4 cups (1 l)
- ☐ Milk or cream · 1 cup
- ☐ Frozen peas · 1 cup
- ☐ Dried thyme · flour

## Ajapsandali

- ☐ Eggplants · 2
- ☐ Potatoes · 3 · carrots · 2
- ☐ Bell peppers · 2
- ☐ Tomatoes · 4 (or 1 can)
- ☐ Small chili (optional)
- ☐ Fresh cilantro, basil & parsley

## Lobio

- ☐ Dried red kidney beans · 400 g (or 3 cans)
- ☐ Walnuts · ½ cup (optional)
- ☐ Blue fenugreek (optional)
- ☐ Fresh cilantro

## Pantry basics (used in several)

- ☐ Onions & garlic
- ☐ Oil · salt · pepper
- ☐ Tomato paste
- ☐ Ground coriander · bay leaves
- ☐ Chili flakes



## 30-minute weekend prep

- Pick 2-3 recipes for the week.
- Chop the onions and mince the garlic for all of them.
- Slice the carrots, celery and peppers.
- Making lobio? Soak the beans the night before.
- Pack each recipe's veggies in its own labeled box or bag.
- On cooking day: open, dump, switch on. Done! 